

Sexy and We Know It: Exploring Sexistemologies for HCI

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Figure 1: Teaser: 3D-printed genitals eagerly await their application.

Abstract

Our (Western) culture is one of sex exceptionalism—sex is constructed as dangerous and taboo on the one hand, and as compulsory and irresistible on the other. This portrayal of sex taints technology design and HCI research in ways that disproportionately harm marginalized groups. But what if we approached sex as simply a lens like any other? Building on previous HCI explorations in this space, we propose sex as a method for critical inquiry, and a means to highlight marginalized knowledges. To delve into the sexistemological potentials of this approach, we conducted two design projects. Based on our insights, we discuss how sex as method could look like, how it can facilitate novel insights about intersecting areas of life, and what ethical considerations this method entails.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **HCI theory, concepts and models; Interaction design process and methods.**

*Both authors contributed equally to this research.

† Author had advisory role and coined the term “sexistemologies” for this paper.

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1 Introduction

Kay and Ekat are having a coffee break at work one day, talking about their personal experiences with erotica and pornography from an autistic perspective, when Kay mentions Chuck Tingle. ‘Who is Chuck Tingle?’, Ekat asks. ‘Chuck Tingle’, Kay explains, ‘is the pseudonym of a writer of mostly gay erotic novels who is also autistic. What I like about Chuck Tingle is that I sort of relate to what he is doing, because I do that kind of stuff too—I feel like he uses sex not just humorously or literarily, but as a sort of method to process things, to try and understand or sort of deal with societal issues... Let me show you’, Kay says, pulling up Chuck Tingle’s website.¹

The *Tinglers*, as Chuck Tingle calls his mostly self-published erotic novels, usually mention being “pounded in the butt” by someone or something, and overwhelmingly feature the protagonist being pounded in the butt not by humans, but by anthropomorphised creatures, objects, and even abstract concepts—to name a

¹<https://www.chucktingle.com/> (last accessed 17-11-2024)



Figure 2: Tingle's, from left to right: Angry Man Pounded by the Fear of His Latent Gayness over a Dinosaur Transitioning into a Unicorn, Glazed by the Gay Living Donuts, I'm Gay for my Living Billionaire Jet Plane, Pounded in the Butt by my own Butt, Oppressed in the Butt by my Inclusive Holiday Coffee Cups, Slammed in the Butt by Donald Tromp's Attempt to Avoid Accusations of Plagiarism by Removing all Facts or Concrete Plans from his Republican National Convention Speech, There's a Bitcoin in My Butt and He Is Handsome

few: reptiles, dinosaurs, unicorns, coffee cups, donuts, bitcoins, linear time, transphobia, speeches made by politicians, reactionary political positions, Mondays, and their own butt. They feature positive and hopeful endings, and despite mostly centering cis gay men, there are also works featuring other queer characters (Chuck Tingle has been active in support of trans rights, and stresses consent in his work).

This work resonated with the two first authors because they both, consciously or subconsciously, use dreams, daydreams, fiction, and fantastical escapism to deal with distressing topics and societal problems they encounter. More importantly, it resonated with them because it uses sex as a lens, or genre, or method *like any other*. Kay and Ekat's interpretation of his oeuvre is: Chuck Tingle uses sex as a method to process not just topics of desire and fun, but also deeply fraught socio-political conflicts, which through the sexual frames he can put into a known setting and bring to a happy conclusion, thus laying them down to rest in his mind. As such, his work is not primarily about sex itself, but about processing the meta-topic *using sex as a method*.

Based on this initial contact with sex as a method, we began discussing the 'simplification' of social justice topics by turning them into sexual fantasy scenarios, and decided to deeper explore the potentials of *sexistemologies*² for HCI research and design.

In the following, we begin by first discussing sex exceptionalism as an important factor for understanding *why* sex as a method can draw on different perspectives to gain insights around intimacies while offering potential pathways for the expression of marginalized knowledges (2). We then propose *sex as method* and situate it within existing HCI research (3). Subsequently, we present two case studies from the two first authors' design research projects that applied sex as a method (4). From this, we discuss our experiences and insights gained from conducting these projects, and describe potential applications and practical considerations for working with *sexistemologies* (5).

2 Foreplay: Sex Exceptionalism

Whether in the media, public education, or policy, our (Western) culture constructs sex as *different* to other human drives, behaviors, or fields of interest. On the one hand, sex is portrayed as mind-changing, druglike, the non-plus-ultra of goals in life and love (especially for heterosexual men). On the other hand, sex is considered dangerous, immoral, and in need to be controlled (particularly when it comes to sexualities of women and queer people). In both positive and negative lights, sex is exceptionalized.

Feminist and queer studies have long been preoccupied with the exceptional status attributed to sex [31, 77, 88]. However, few sources explicitly work with the term *sex exceptionalism*. Searching for what we expected to be an established concept, we were surprised to find only a few articles from the context of legal studies. Herein, Aya Gruber [35], coining the term *sex exceptionalism*, writes: "People generally believe that sexual assault is graver than nonsexual assault, uninvited sexual compliments are worse than nonsexual insults, and sex work is different from work" [35, p. 755], adding that "this exceptionalist treatment of sex as categorically different rarely elicits discussion, much less debate" [ibid]. Throughout her article, Gruber [35] outlines how, historically, sex exceptionalism in US criminal law is rooted in ideas of controlling female sexuality and reproduction and racial supremacy. Gruber calls out how sex "dazzles" theorists, activists and scholars across all disciplines to believe it is something exceptional.

Indeed, it seems that HCI researchers and practitioners are similarly dazzled by sex as a subject matter. While Kannabiran et al. (2011) identified a growing interest in sexuality research in HCI a decade ago [47], works in this space still remain scant and are often deemed inconsiderable, not least due to prejudice, controversy, salaciousness and taboo [12, 42, 46, 82]. Kannabiran et al. specifically name taboo as one of the main barriers of entry, describing cases where HCI sexuality research is perceived as too outrageous to state explicitly, morally questionable, or potentially career-endangering [47]. Existing research is commonly permeated by norms and misconceptions [43, 67], and disregards entire groups, such as older people, disabled people, queer people, or sex workers [9, 42, 46, 49, 80]. Likewise, normative and exceptionalist

²The term is specifically the creation of the third author, Katta Spiel.

assumptions around sex shape the design of associated technologies [28, 29, 43, 52, 65, 91].

In the following, we borrow Gruber’s term “sex exceptionalism” to discuss the both negative and positive fallacies of this special status of sex and its implications for HCI. In doing so, we illuminate how the exceptionalisation of sex contributes to the marginalization of certain groups. Specifically, by constructing non-conforming sexual practices, communities and cultures as deviant, those affected are bereaved of crucial infrastructural and communal elements that are entangled with those practices [11, 20, 64, 90]. At the same time, constructing sex as exceptional in the positive sense, people are pressured into accepting sexuality as paramount in their lives [15, 37, 73], often without being equipped with the knowledge or empowerment necessary to do so (or not) on their own terms.

2.1 Constructing Deviance Through Sex Exceptionalism

Discussing the politics of sexuality as a mode of oppression in her 1984 essay *Thinking Sex*, Gayle Rubin highlights the *fallacy of misplaced scale* [77]. Sex exceptionalism by any other name, this fallacy concludes from a sex-negative line of thought: because sex is inherently dangerous, corrupting and destructive (as Western hegemonic culture deems it to be), every act and practice pertaining to sex is treated as a *special case* [77]. Consequently, especially those sexualities and sexual practices that diverge from a heteronormative, patriarchal norm (e.g., those of women, queer, disabled or racialized people) are framed as taboo and aberrant, made impossible or sanctioned [11, 57, 61, 77, 92].

Given their societal pervasiveness, technologies, too, intertwine with these norms. For instance, while pornography (or media considered as such today) has had many functions throughout history (e.g., as sex education material, political satire, or as a conversation about gender, the body, and intimate desires among the upper classes), its circulation among the laboring classes of Western Europe in the 17th and 18th centuries, facilitated by the printing press and increasing literacy, was followed by its construction as immoral, dangerous and in need of regulation [58, 89]. Current-day debates around pornography in the West continue to be tainted by these views—instead of improving education to facilitate the critical and ethical consumption of *media in general*, pornography is singled out as different, putatively dangerous media that society needs to specifically be protected from [17, 25]. At the same time, slasher horror films depicting women being brutally murdered are, by far, not scrutinized in the same way in popular discourse. This frames female sex and sexual pleasure as *more dangerous and morally reprehensible* than femicide.

Commonly, this discourse portrays pornographic actresses and sex workers as devoid of agency, passive and oppressed (disregarding that pornography can be an empowering form of challenging patriarchal norms of femininity [63]), while simultaneously, there is little push to make working conditions in these areas more equitable or transparent—regulations pretending to protect sex workers from precarious working conditions are merely further stigmatizing instances of morality politics [87]. Consequently, these notions shape how online platforms are designed, governed and researched. While online sex work is akin to other forms of digital entrepreneurialism,

it is usually devalued as non-work or ‘bad’ work in digital labor discourses [74]. More: sex workers regularly find their labor practices restrained by platform governance structures enforced by the puritanical values of the American-dominated internet [9, 26, 74].

While Western culture is far from homogeneous, and this approach to content moderation is not universal (even within the US itself), the economic and cultural dominance of these puritanical values in US-based tech companies nevertheless means that any platformed community regularly finds itself subjected to them [9, 14, 84, 85]. This does not end with sexual content: even media *adjacent* to sex and not intended for erotic purposes (e.g., educational content) are rendered taboo or considered ‘pornographic’ as well. For some marginalized communities, such as trans people, this can directly cut them off from educational material about their own bodies, impinging upon their personhood, further framing them as deviant and diminishing their possibilities to protect themselves [13, 64].

As narrow conceptions of ‘normal’ sexualities govern every increment of a platforms’ design, those rendered *other* by these conceptions are constantly constrained in navigating online spaces. Park et al. [66], for instance, highlight how the technological affordances of online dating platforms pressure queer women into conforming their sexualities and relationship expectations to normative gender expressions and romantic ideals, while Porter et al. [71] illustrate how disabled people engaging in online dating have to perform additional labor to filter potentially ableist interlocutors in the absence of a dedicated platform feature. In these examples, the exceptionalization of sex as taboo deprives marginalized groups of online spaces and resources crucial for their livelihood, wellbeing, community or safety.³

Importantly, this exceptionalisation attributes inflated meaning to sexual content, ignoring that some of it is just an outlet for exploration [5, 70]. Why is watching a hard core porno considered worse than watching a slasher film? Because it is assumed that the hard core porno is more likely to become a reality. In the next section, we discuss the framing of sex as compulsory and exceptionally positive as another fallacy advanced by sex exceptionalism.

2.2 Sex Exceptionalism and Compulsory Sexuality

Paradoxically, sex exceptionalism is simultaneously a catalyst for *compulsory sexuality*. Compulsory sexuality, as defined by Kristina Gupta [36], is “the assumption that all people are sexual and [describes] the social norms and practices that both marginalize various forms of nonsexuality, such as a lack of sexual desire or behavior, and compel people to experience themselves as desiring subjects, take up sexual identities, and engage in sexual activity” [36, p. 132]. Through this lens, asexual people are rendered abnormal, pathological, or unhuman [10, 15]. Whether in media representations, interpersonal interactions, or medical guidelines,⁴ asexual⁵ people

³Historically, this development is comparable to puritan regulations of offline spaces. For instance, the disappearance of gay and lesbian explicit sexual material, and dedicated clubs and theaters from public spaces across the US deprived them of spaces that bear potential for political communities and that are safe from violence [11, 16, 20, 41].

⁴Psychiatry, for instance, still pathologizes absent/low sexual interest/desire/arousal [60].

⁵Broadly, the label *asexual* is “adopted by many people who identify with the definition of ‘having little to no sexual attraction and/or desire’”, while it is important to note that

are discursively constructed as ‘impossible’ and in need to be ‘fixed’ (even if done so by violent, nonconsensual means) [15], while being denied epistemic authority on their identities [15, 18, 37, 73, 76]. Yet another means to weaponize sexuality as a tool for social control [36, 77, 81], compulsory sexuality is deeply entrenched in patriarchal, heteronormative, racist and ableist norms [15, 51]. Entwining with notions of sexual normalcy (cf. 2.1), compulsory sexuality supports biologicistic rationales perpetuating heteronormative power and furthering patriarchal sexual violence [23, 44].

While socially destructive drives and fantasies are commonly suppressed for society’s benefit or our personal health, the normative dogma rooted in rape culture [94] and compulsory sexuality constructs sexual drives or fantasies as irresistible and to be acted out at all cost. This fuels mythological narratives justifying sexual offenders because they ‘couldn’t help themselves’ and blaming victims for provoking the male desire too much. It also supports incel⁶ narratives, framing the female body and sex as something that is owed to men [50]. Compulsory sexuality is not limited to heterosexual dynamics, but is also experienced within queer social circles. Tying queer identity *solely* to sex acts (as is still common in mainstream queer discourse) not only overly sexualizes *all* queer people, but also gatekeeps asexual people from queer communities [15, 22]. Not only do sex exceptionalist norms permeate queer cultures, but queer expressions challenging these norms are often commodified, distorted, and absorbed into hegemonial narratives. This becomes observable on digital platforms such as Pornhub, where “transgender” was the third most popular category in the US in 2022 even while legislation severely curbing the rights of trans people was being implemented [27], or TikTok, where queer masculinities are copied and ridiculed to reinforce traditional and toxic masculinities [30].

In HCI, asexual identities and intimacies remain invisible: Reviewing HCI research about LGBTQ+⁷ people, Taylor et al. [83] found zero results related to asexuality [83]. Other scientific fields still largely draw on pathologizing representations of asexuality [72]. Such biologicistic notions of compulsory sexuality permeate the design of intimate technologies, such as sex toys. For instance, Osipova et al. [65] found the teledildonics company *KIIROO* marketing their products as treatments for sexual aversions [65]. Similarly, Kloe [52] highlights how the *Lioness* smart vibrator equates sexual pleasure with physiological responses in its data visualization, reinforcing dangerous and heavily criticized narratives about women, their bodies and sexuality [52].

Taken together, sex exceptionalism and compulsory sexuality perpetuate both negative and positive fallacies around sex—it is both dangerous and taboo and essential and irrepressible. As a consequence, sex exceptionalism shapes how technologies are researched and designed. Especially to those who do not meet sex exceptionalist

norms, technologies become inaccessible, constraining, normalizing, and erasing. In the realm of research, sex exceptionalism limits what can be considered appropriate to inquire, discuss and draw attention to. Normative assumptions govern how sex is conceptualized, and whose sexualities are in focus and whose are left out. As HCI scholars and practitioners, we need to critically examine what role these fallacies play in our work to avoid ignorance and harm of marginalized communities and practices. More: the political nature of sex situates it as an epistemological tool for both inquiring existing norms and values, and exploring alternatives on how we understand and design for sexuality and related areas of life.

3 Emancipatory Potentials of Sexistemologies: Sex as Method

Contrary to the myth of sex as eternal, unchanging, private and thus de-politicized, we contend that sex is, in the words of Rubin [77], “as much a human product as are diets, methods of transportation, systems of etiquette, forms of labour, types of entertainment, processes of production, and modes of oppression” [77, p. 147]. Sex is nothing more than one of *many* forms of experiencing and interacting with the world, and can be as dazzling or mundane, as pivotal or irrelevant, as it is individually or socially considered to be.

This is a relatively banal, yet powerful conceptualization: pushing sex off its exceptional pedestal equips us with the tools necessary to deconstruct the toxic and oppressive norms assigned as essential. Instead, sex and sexual content can be *anything*: a lens, an activity, a fun way to engage with topics from personal identity to socio-political issues. This is why Chuck Tingle’s surreal novelettes on butt-pounding coffee cups and reactionary politics are so intriguing to us. **When it comes to narrative, sex is a relatively confined framework within a well-demarcated situational setting—and yet, carries the proverbial weight of the world on its shoulders: imbued with unparalleled amounts of meaning, a battle-ground for every imaginable political debate, and entangled in nearly all aspects of society and everyday life, it presents the perfect tool for inquiry. Sex is a method.**

HCI research has already begun exploring sex as an epistemological lens. Reviewing HCI literature on sexuality, Kannabiran et al. identify “sexuality as a methodological apparatus” [47, p. 700] as an incidental focus in research of interpersonal dynamics, criticizing that this line of research tends to gloss over sexuality’s potential as a mode of knowing precisely because of this incidental nature [47]. Further examples of the analytical opportunities of sexuality can be found in research broadly subsumed under the term *technosexuality*. These works take a holistic approach to technologies and sexuality as both continuously shaping, attuning and transforming each other, while influencing intersecting domains such as pleasure, health, identity, design, or self-expression [6, 8, 48]. For instance, Bardzell et al. [7] highlight how online sexual niche communities cultivate novel intimate practices that impact the person in front of the computer screen in both positive and negative ways, be it by facilitating users’ self-cultivation, growth, and care of themselves, or inviting inscrutable or repugnant behaviors [7]. Moreover, Su et al. [82] show how even technologies usually associated with

asexuality (like sexuality) is a spectrum and might, e.g., also include people “gravitating toward ‘varying levels of sexual attraction and/or desire’ [or] ‘experiencing only secondary sexual attraction and/or desire’ in acutely specific contexts or only with specific people” [15, p. 4].

⁶Short for “involuntary celibates,” a misogynistic online subculture consisting mostly of men hostile towards women whom they perceive as owing them sex, but not giving them any inc [2].

⁷lesbian, gay, bisexual, trans, queer people and those belonging to other orientations, genders, and identities

‘reckless’ sex (here, sex dolls) are entangled in a range of complex forms of intimacies, emotional bonds, and intimate fictions taking place within a user-artifact relation [82].

We propose pushing these emerging explorations towards **the purposeful and explicit construction and application of sex as a method**, and extending inquiry based on sex as a method **beyond topics of the intimate, romantic, or otherwise directly sex-adjacent**. We propose wholeheartedly embracing different **sexistemologies**, as a filter, a lens we experience and understand the world through—with all its multitudinous facets.

Evidently, the proposition to apply sex as a method immediately begs the question—what exactly *is* sex? Is it eroticism? Is it arousal-related playful engagement with the world? Is it desire, is it kink? Or something other entirely? Following along the lines of [38, 88], for the time being, we refrain from defining sex, choosing instead to remain within the tension between hegemonial, exceptionalist, genital understandings of sex as described above, and oppositional marginalized, de-exceptionalized or expanded understandings. Working with to work against hegemonial norms and exceptional mythologization is key to our epistemological aim of applying it as a method, and to our general aim of queer and crip⁸ liberation: Historically, sex practices and communities that opposed sexual norms were the arena for enacting change and liberation—crip and queer people understand that sex is not necessarily always sexual, but *always* political [4, 73, 93]. Our own positionality on this topic comes from our crip and queer body-minds that were constantly at odds with sexual exceptionalism. As such, we apply crip and queer epistemological framings to our applications [61]. In the following, we present two case studies where we applied sex as a method within this framework.

4 Case Studies

The two first authors conducted a workshop (4.1) and designed an installation (4.2) for the *Arse Elektronika* Festival 2023.⁹ While not connected to each other, both offered new sexistemological insights on social norms around sex and gender in the context of (re)production technologies and communities relating to these technologies. We documented our encounters with visitors in written reflections after the festival, with participants for both projects giving verbal consent for their stories, experiences and/or drawings to be discussed in future academic work.

4.1 Copy-Paste Hentai

The workshop *Copy-Paste Hentai*¹⁰ invited festival visitors to create erotic artworks in *hentai*¹⁰ style while reflecting on critical questions about the societal power inequalities that shape our most intimate desires. Visitors used both AI-generated and hand-drawn

collage cutouts and different drawing materials to either follow one of our three prompts of varying explicitness, or to create freely. Finished artworks, given their creators’ consent, were scanned, printed and displayed, adding to a growing collection throughout the festival. As visitors were creating their erotica, when their creative flow allowed, we engaged them in conversations with us and one another on socio-cultural issues connected to Western, internet-based consumption of *hentai* specifically, and online pornography more broadly.



Figure 3: Visitors working on their erotica.

Drawing on previous work examining the cultural reproduction of oppressive sexual structures in personal sexual fantasies [39, 53] and erotic desire as an arena for making sense of intersectional oppression and social power dynamics [39], we created three posters with infographics to scaffold these critical conversations. The first asked quite general critical questions about the topic at hand, such as “*how many of our sexual fantasies are actually about power?*” or “*how does misogyny feature in hentai?*” and contained short explanations of the *Born Sexy Yesterday*¹¹ trope, and the concept of *Consensual Non-Consent*¹². The second poster revolved around the exoticization of *hentai* as appropriated by the West, where *hentai* are, often illegally, digitally copied and distributed by online communities on *scanlation*¹³ platforms. This poster included clarifications of the term *hentai*, a short history of *shunga*¹⁴ and *manga* erotica, and short explanations of *Romantic Racism* and *Racial Fetishizing*. This poster asked visitors questions such as “*What are sexual stereotypes around East and South-East Asian (ESEA) women & men?*” and “*Why does a certain body, a certain outfit, a certain expression, a certain aesthetic, a certain situation appeal to you?*” The third poster focused on heteronormativity and introduced queer perspectives, questioning the predominance of male sexual violence (usually against femme characters) in *hentai*, featuring short explanations on *Queering* and *Futanari*,¹⁵ and asking questions such as “*How could we use Hentai*

⁸The term “crip” is a shorthand for and reclamation of the slur “cripple” [59, 78]. The term is claimed as a self-designation, an intra-group term or to describe activist movements and academic lines of thought. Its use stands in defiance of bodymind norms rooted in ableism and compulsory able-bodiedness and fosters empowerment and solidarity among those not fitting these norms [19, 45, 61, 78].

⁹Inaugurated in 2007, *Arse Elektronika* is an annual festival on technology and sexuality organized by the art collective *monochrom*. In 2023 it collaborated with the better-known *Ars Electronica* festival for art and technology, and was held in Linz, Austria. For more information, see also <https://monochrom.at/arse-elektronika/2023/about.html> (last accessed 2024-12-04).

¹⁰Western term for erotic manga or anime, from Japanese 変態 (transformation, metamorphosis).

¹¹A popular fiction trope of a childish personality existing in a sexualized adult femme body [68]; see also [69].

¹²Consensual Non-Consent (CNC) is a type of play with resistance from one of the parties to the advances of another. Usually CNC is a kinky roleplay of sexual violence, where often part of the fun is saying no and begging to stop. See also [33].

¹³Portmanteau of scanning and translation, sites that host fan translations of popular manga. Scanlation is a pillar of online culture around manga, including hentai. See e.g., [1].

¹⁴Historical Japanese *ukiyo-e* erotica, popular in the Edo/Tokugawa period.

¹⁵Originally a Japanese concept, *Futanari* in the context of Western consumption of *hentai* erotica have since expanded into a pornographic genre featuring usually animated, strong and assertive femme bodies with usually enormous penises [32].

to queer sex and explore our own vulnerabilities beyond heterosexist norms?"

Mediated by the posters and the collage activities (which we also engaged in while conversing), participants ruminated on their personal attitudes towards pornography and erotic art. Although not all necessarily opened up about their personal desires or preferences, many were inspired to interrogate previously unquestioned assumptions, change their minds about things, and even express deep insecurities about what they consider ethical or unethical when it comes to pornography, illustrated or otherwise. Regardless of their knowledge about *hentai* specifically, which not all participants were familiar with, many ruminated on how the internet has shaped the creation and sharing of pornography in this context.

While a few participants created their own drawings entirely without using the collage materials, most participants initially expressed shyness, and chose to either entirely rely on the existing collage material, or to create a base with the material and draw over it, thus distancing themselves from the explicit nature of the illustrations. Several cis white persons adjacent to hacker culture ended up not creating pornographic content or turning it into a joke to mask potential discomfort and circumvent vulnerability. To our delight, one participant decided to subvert the workshop by turning explicit images non-sexual (e.g. oral sex becomes eating ice-cream—see Fig. 4). To us, this was different to the aforementioned 'joke-defense' mechanism: this was full and earnest engagement with the material; an honest and deeply felt problematization of everything revolving around sex all the time *at a festival about sex and technology*.

This workshop helped us deepen our methodological expertise around the application of proxies in participatory design and education (cf. [3, 79]). Through the process of preparing this workshop, we obtained insights into the effects the vast digital repository of online manga and hentai culture has left us with, as well as the constraints of cultural power placed on sexuality. The process of creating the workshop material also led to an unexpected exploration of the limits of generative AI: our initial (misguided) idea was to create collage material using AI, however, even in manga style, the US-based AI¹⁶ we were using refused to create not only pornographic, but overall nude material, was incapable of creating fat bodies that were lightly clothed or sensual in this style, and kept trying to insert women into patterns containing *kitchen appliances*. Frustrated, we decided to manually copy and lightly remix existing artwork from popular scanlation sites, as well as create our own original artwork for the collage material, using AI-generated art only for backgrounds and props. We discuss our insights in more detail in 5.

4.2 Object Sexualification

While above workshop concerned human experiences with sexuality and explored artisanal artefacts distributed and reproduced through digital technologies, the installation *Object Sexualification* examined the sexual experiences of human-surrounding environments through digitally and mechanically produced artefacts. A vending machine invited visitors to purchase (for the price of 1€) 3D-printed iridescent genitalia (5cm in diameter) with an adhesive

back side. On a screen beside the machine, a silent video similar in style to live pornographic films was playing, featuring a lamp, a mug, a stapler and a dictaphone engaging in group sex. All objects were sporting different 3D-printed genitals stuck on them by human hands prior to their sexual encounter. At the beginning of the video, the production process was shown, overlaid with the project description text:

"From the dawn of time, objects have been condemned to a dull, inanimate existence, serving only human sexual pleasure. Now, with this groundbreaking innovation, built with state-of-the-art technology, we humans can help objects embark in thrilling sexual escapades and live out their wildest, dirtiest fantasies! Don't miss the opportunity to be part of this revolutionary journey of Object Sexualification!"

We are inseparably entangled with the material world, shaping objects while objects shape us in return [21]. However, when it comes to intimacy, objects are primarily understood as mediators of human-to-human intimacies, with HCI research focusing on this mediation with the human at the center (e.g. [40, 86]). Meanwhile, newer technologies such as teledildonics augment our intimate interactions onto the 'outside' world, connecting us to virtually anyone and *anything* [55, 56]. In our culture, non-sexual objects usually tend to be, humorously, associated with sex if they resemble genitalia, particularly phalluses (e.g. rockets, towers, bananas). In a bid to break even the asymmetry between people and things (as argued by [34]), we turned our 'sexualisation spectacles' up a notch and decided to equalize the playing ground by making any and all objects sexual through bestowing them their own diverse genitals. In so doing, the norms are reversed: humans become the medium through which objects assume their sexual existence, lending them their genitals as portals to sexuality.¹⁷

As with the project presented above, we gleaned unexpected insights into digital reproduction techniques in creating our material: due to financial constraints, we were unable to afford the creation of bespoke and diverse genitalia, and resorted to 3D model files found online. Browsing different databases, we were presented mainly with comically proportioned erect dildo-style penises, while what scarcity of vulvas existed were mostly intended as models for biological and medical education. There was a resonating and worrying lack of trans and inter* genitals, flaccid penises or protruding inner labia. With our nonexistent 3D-modelling skills, we managed to fuse some existing penises and vulvas into unrealistic inter* or trans genitals, but more was unachievable with the resources we had. Thus, we unwillingly ended up materially reproducing the phallogocentric norms of 3D-printing databases [62]. More deliberate, in contrast to this, was our reproduction of pornographic filming and aesthetic norms: we were surprised at how easily techniques such as dim lighting, point-of-view, rhythmic movements of objects, and timing of cuts immediately transported the recognizable genre of a typical penetration-centric pornographic short film, despite the complete absence of sound or human bodies.

Visitor interactions with the artifact brought up various provocations. One visitor recognized a vulva looking like their own, and

¹⁶specifically, Midjourney

¹⁷An association dominant in our culture, where genitalia are equated to sex and thus, sexualisation.



Figure 4: One participant's complication of compulsory sexuality.



Figure 5: Object Sexualification installation at the Arse Elektronika festival.

wished to own that particular model. Another visitor ruminated the randomness of not knowing which genital would come out of the machine: “It’s like dating, you never know what you’ll get.” Yet another visitor was trying to choose a “dick” to gift their grandmother, who they described as conservative, implying that only a penis would be considered appropriate to possess, while a vulva, trans or inter* genital would be inappropriate. Another visitor stuck an inter* genital to the backside of a rotating fan, which began lightly vibrating once turned on, rendering the genital in-motion. Finally, after the exhibition ended, we put the vending machine, which still had some of its more than 300 genitals stocked, in our office at our research institute. Here, it has often led to colleagues, guest researchers and other visitors engaging in a conversation with us after looking at the machine or receiving a genital. In direct opposition to its goal of facilitating object sexual encounters, the vending machine ended up facilitating human, non-sexual encounters. In the following, we reflect on our sexistemological insights obtained from both projects and their implications for sex as method in more detail.

5 Aftercare: Critical Reflections on Sex as Method

Both the workshop and the installation facilitated low-pressure, high-mediation engagement with topics usually considered private, to some extent even taboo, and thus often associated with

feelings like discomfort or shame. Visitors interacting with the installation shared their perspectives on, and relations to, genitals: what norms they perceive associated with them, how their personal values diverge from these norms, and how taboo facilitates the thrill of decorating everyday objects with genitals. Meanwhile, visitors to the workshop discussed the ethics and boundaries of sexual fantasies both generally and personally, questioning where these fantasies come from, and in one case, opposing them altogether. Importantly, the presentation format of both projects made critical inquiry not only fun, but accessible to non-academic audiences, bridging disciplinary divides and circumventing academic gatekeeping of critical education.

We as researchers, during the design and facilitation process of both projects, obtained both expected and unexpected insights into cultural norms and associations around sex, desire, pornography, and genitals. Our search for 3D model files of genitals highlighted our culture’s fixation on (erect) penises, the medicalization of vulvas, and the erasure of genitals outside the binary, while our attempts to harness AI-generated image material, and our browsing of *hentai* sites, revealed cultural norms in specific areas and insights about the economization of erotica. Herein, sex as a method led to insights otherwise not obtainable, as the 3D model databases and AI platform we used are mediated by sex exceptionalist norms in the ways they are designed and governed.

Our most relevant learning in terms of methodological application was the distance afforded by the formats’ mediation. The formats presented above facilitated conversations that may otherwise have been inappropriate or impossible to broach. By creating the right amount and manner of distance between persons and conversations about sex, these encounters and discussions fostered community and mutual understanding, for some even new-found insights or validation. We found that collage, a method based on using another person’s (in this case, erotic) artwork as raw material, helped create a sense of distance between participants and their work, a distance especially relevant when talking about intimate and potentially stigmatizing topics (cf. [24, 75]). Similarly, discussing another person’s, or entirely fictional, genitals allowed for reflections around genitals that may otherwise have been uncomfortable or too intimate to share with strangers, even given a sex-related setting (cf. [3, 79]). Relying on existing material as proxies made participants feel less vulnerable when engaging with such sensitive topics as erotica or sexual fantasies, encouraging them to share their personal thoughts and experiences.

We were surprised at how almost every visitor, given these conditions, was willing, even *eager*, to de-exceptionalize sex; at how many of the people we spoke to were frustrated by cultural norms relating to sex, some although mentioning they had never really thought about these things. From this, many visitors drew parallels to societal issues or everyday practices and norms unrelated to sex as such—however, others chose to remain within the contextual discussion. This is relevant to understanding the function of sexist-mologies: **the well-delineated context of sex, while inviting participants to project their insights beyond this context, does not necessitate this extension.** Thus, participants could choose to keep their ethical or critical considerations *within* the context of sex for the time being. This was especially relevant to those realizing their desires stemmed from unethical oppressive norms: given the disturbing nature of some insights participants may have gained about themselves or others, allowing the retention of the narrative boundary was an essential protective mechanism (along with the distance created by the mediating materials and formats).

As touched upon at the end of 3, paradoxically, **the very exceptionalism of sex we are working against is precisely what renders sex as a method so effective**, imbuing sex with disproportionate meaning and thus lending it the potential to counteract the very exceptionalism that gives it power. Sex as a method walks the thin line between accepting exceptionalism to ingrain sex with meaning, and de-exceptionalising just enough to critically engage with hegemonic norms; just as the hegemonic norms and fallacies around sex must be acknowledged in order to contradict them. Therefore, **sex as method cannot exist without constitutive and continuous ethical considerations** beyond basic research ethics—we present our initial thoughts to this end below.

5.1 Apply with Care: Ethics of Sex as Method

Sexistemologies can only be emancipatory if they include social justice, i.e. if this mode of knowing is practiced from critical standpoint [54]. By virtue of its application as a lens to understand structures of power and oppression, these structures need to be acknowledged and considered in its application.

The ethics of sex as method are fragile in that the possibility of reifying norms looms behind any attempt to critically engage with them. From our own experience, while conducting the *Copy-Paste Hentai!* workshop, we had to change our approach to make clear the critical purpose earlier on after one visitor drew our attention to the lack of diversity in bodies, gleaned from our copying existing *hentai* art to showcase their problematic attributes. Despite making several modifications from our part to include trans and fat bodies and bodies of color as starting points to spark ideas, most of the material was representative of what *was* rather than what *could be*, reifying norms among visitors who did not engage long enough to have a critical discussion. Another example of this fragility is the context and setting that facilitates vulnerable discussions: when a group of people joining our workshop treated it as a joke to avoid vulnerable discussions, other participants stopped feeling comfortable opening up and earnestly talking about the topics at hand.

Finally, sex as method itself is fragile: as mentioned above, should the exceptionalist and hegemonial norms change, the method may well become ineffective. If sex became truly de-exceptionalised, with all effects following, then sex could become less fraught with tension, and may no longer be as rich a context in terms of research insights.

6 Conclusion

We are socialized from the very beginning to see sex as exceptional in both positive and negative ways: as a forbidden and shameful activity, sex is rendered taboo and dangerous, while simultaneously, sex is constructed as an absolute necessity and uncontrollable force. Given its ubiquity, sex exceptionalist thought taints HCI research and design.

Building on prior HCI explorations in this space, we proposed sex as a method and tool for critical inquiry. We conducted two case studies investigating the sexist-mological potentials of this method. We found, that imbued with such disproportionate meaning and tensions, sex as method has the potential to offer rich insights into a range of domains intersecting with this subject—be it antecedent to, entangled with, or everything other than sex.

Notably, sexist-mologies are multiple. While the methodological and epistemological insights we obtained from our case studies are specific to our work, there are potentially numerous ways for leveraging sex as a mode of knowing. Future studies building on this investigation could pursue sex as method for participatory engagements—e.g. in participatory design workshops to explore how materialities can challenge and re-produce sex exceptionalism, or to speculate about worlds where meanings attributed to sex (and associated technologies) are different from ours. Another intriguing research path could be applying sex as a lens for analyzing technologies and digital media to learn about intersecting values and practices. In Tingle-esque manner, such readings could be applied to technologies that are not necessarily intended for sexual interactions. Moreover, conducting such explorations from a different positionality or cultural context is likely to yield different insights not only on the subject matter itself but also on the methodological function of sex. We are excited to see future work exploring sexist-mological approaches and potentials.

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